

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 24

By Clemmons

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of the legendary Kris Kristofferson.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Kris Kristofferson, an uncompromising artist and songwriter whose lyricism transformed country music and ushered in a new era for the art form; and

WHEREAS, he was an important part of the Outlaw movement in country music that changed the genre forever and inspired generations of artists; and

WHEREAS, arguably the greatest songwriter of his generation, Kris Kristofferson was also a Renaissance man; he was a poet, a troubadour, and a storyteller, but also a Rhodes scholar, boxer, pilot, and actor; and

WHEREAS, the son of a U.S. Air Force veteran and commercial pilot, Kris Kristofferson grew up in California and graduated Phi Beta Kappa from Pomona College; and

WHEREAS, after receiving a prestigious Rhodes Scholarship, he earned a master's degree in English literature from Oxford University; and

WHEREAS, Kris Kristofferson returned to California for a short visit, but after rekindling a romance with his former girlfriend and future wife and then starting a family with her, he decided to forgo future studies at Oxford in favor of the U.S. Army; and

WHEREAS, he served as a helicopter pilot in the Army and eventually earned the rank of captain; during a three-year stint in West Germany, he formed his first band; and

WHEREAS, he scuttled his plans to teach English literature at West Point after visiting Nashville for the first time; he became enamored with the close-knit circle of songwriters in Music City and quickly joined their ranks; and

WHEREAS, while working as a janitor at Columbia Records, Kris Kristofferson honed his songwriting craft and hustled demos; his compositions were soon in high demand as they placed on the charts via recordings by diverse country music artists; perhaps most notable

among these early songs is the iconic "Me and Bobby McGee," which would later become a posthumous hit for Janis Joplin; and

WHEREAS, his path to stardom as a performing artist included a stint at the Bitter End in Greenwich Village and an opening set in support of Johnny Cash at the Newport Folk Festival; and

WHEREAS, Kris Kristofferson was signed to Monument Records in 1970 and released more than twenty albums over the course of his illustrious career; his recording of his own "Lovin' Her Was Easier (Than Anything I'll Ever Do Again)" from his second album was a top-five adult contemporary hit and also reached the pop top thirty; and

WHEREAS, he was nominated for several Grammys and won the award three times, including the Grammy for 1971's Best Country Song, "Help Me Make It Through the Night"; and

WHEREAS, in 1970, Kris Kristofferson's "For the Good Times"" was named the Academy of Country Music's Song of the Year, while Johnny Cash's version of his "Sunday Mornin' Comin' Down" secured the Song of the Year award from the Country Music Association; this double win for Song of the Year marked the only time a single individual has ever won the same award from the ACM and CMA in the same year for two different songs; and

WHEREAS, at a low point in his life, Kris Kristofferson was moved by an altar call while visiting a church, and this spiritual experience inspired him to write and record "Why Me," which climbed the charts to become his first number-one country song and his best-selling pop single as a solo artist; and

WHEREAS, in 1985, he joined friends Willie Nelson, Waylon Jennings, and Johnny Cash to form the super group The Highwaymen, and their recording of Jimmy Webb's "Highwayman" gave Kris Kristofferson his second number-one country single; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his phenomenal success as a singer-songwriter, Kris Kristofferson frequently appeared on the big screen, acting in more than fifty films over four decades; and

WHEREAS, after making his film debut in 1971, Kris Kristofferson starred with Bob Dylan in *Pat Garrett and Billy the Kid*, for which he earned a BAFTA nomination; he also played the male lead in the Oscar-winning *Alice Doesn't Live Here Anymore*; the drama *The Sailor Who Fell From Grace With the Sea*; and a remake of *A Star Is Born*, for which he won a Golden Globe in a co-starring role alongside Barbara Streisand; and

WHEREAS, among his later films, Kris Kristofferson will be best remembered for his role in the masterful crime drama *Lone Star* and his appearances in the *Blade* trilogy; and

WHEREAS, in 2023, he gave one of his final performances, singing "Lovin' Her Was Easier (Than Anything I'll Ever Do Again)" with Roseanne Cash at Willie Nelson's ninetieth birthday party; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this gifted artist and fine human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Kris Kristofferson, reflecting fondly upon his many contributions to music as a performer and songwriter, to film as an actor, and to society as a man of social conscience and integrity.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to Kris Kristofferson's widow, Lisa Meyers, and his children and grandchildren.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.